

8-Week Karting Driver Training Plan

Sample programme · Intermediate level · 3 sessions per week + race-day routine

Karting punishes the body in very specific places: the **neck** fights lateral g-forces corner after corner, the **forearms and grip** work against an unassisted steering wheel and kart vibration, and the **core** braces you in a rigid seat with no suspension. General gym programmes rarely train any of this. This 8-week plan targets exactly those demands so you finish your next track day as fast on the last stint as on the first.

Who this plan is for

Amateur karting and track-day drivers who train independently, already do some form of exercise, attend several events per year, and have felt neck, core or forearm fatigue cutting their sessions short.

How the plan works

Session	Focus	Time	Equipment
Session A — Strength	Full-body strength with motorsport bias (posterior chain, pressing, carries)	45–55 min	Barbell or dumbbells
Session B — Driver circuit	Neck, core anti-rotation, grip endurance — the karting-specific work	30–40 min	Bands, plate, towel
Session C — Conditioning	Heart-rate work matched to stint length, plus mobility	30–40 min	Bike / rower / run

The plan runs as **two 4-week blocks**. Block 1 (weeks 1–4) builds a base and ends with a light deload week. Block 2 (weeks 5–8) raises intensity and karting-specific volume, ending with a **taper week** that leaves you fresh for an event weekend. Leave at least one rest day between sessions (e.g. Mon A / Wed B / Fri C).

Weekly structure at a glance

Week	Phase	Strength (A)	Driver circuit (B)	Conditioning (C)	RPE
1	Base	3 sets, moderate load	2 rounds	4 × 3 min intervals	6–7
2	Base	3 sets, add load	2 rounds	4 × 3 min	7
3	Build	4 sets	3 rounds	5 × 3 min	7–8
4	Deload	2 light sets	2 rounds, easy	20 min easy	5
5	Build	4 sets, heavier top set	3 rounds	5 × 3 min, shorter rest	7–8
6	Build	4 sets, add load	4 rounds	6 × 3 min	8
7	Peak	4 sets, heaviest week	4 rounds + progressions	6 × 3 min, 90 s rest	8
8	Taper	2 light sets	2 rounds	20 min easy	5

RPE = rating of perceived exertion (10 = maximal effort). If a listed weight and the RPE disagree, trust the RPE.

Session A — Strength (2× per week optional, minimum 1×)

Exercise	Sets × Reps	Rest	Why it matters for karting
Goblet or barbell squat	3–4 × 8	2 min	Leg drive for braking pressure; hip stability in the seat
Romanian deadlift	3 × 10	2 min	Posterior chain — protects the lower back from kart vibration
Single-arm dumbbell row	3 × 10 / side	90 s	Pulling strength for steering corrections
Half-kneeling overhead press	3 × 8 / side	90 s	Shoulder endurance for holding the wheel under load
Farmer's carry	3 × 30 m heavy	90 s	Grip endurance + trunk bracing in one movement
Palloy press (band)	3 × 12 / side	60 s	Anti-rotation core — resisting lateral g in corners

Warm-up before every session: 5 min easy cardio + arm circles, hip openers, neck rotations (2 min).

Session B — Driver circuit (the karting-specific session)

Perform as a circuit: one exercise after another, 60–90 s rest between rounds. Rounds per week: W1–2 = 2, W3 = 3, W4 = 2 (easy), W5 = 3, W6–7 = 4, W8 = 2. In weeks 6–7 add the listed progressions (longer holds, small plate increments, added rotations).

Exercise	Dose per round	Coaching cue
Neck isometric holds (4 directions, band or hand resistance)	2 × 10 s each direction	Push head into resistance without moving; build to 15 s by week 6
Lateral neck flexion with light plate (lying on side)	10–12 / side	Slow and controlled — this is the muscle that dies first in a long stint
Plank with shoulder taps	30–45 s	Hips stay level; simulates bracing while hands are busy
Side plank	20–30 s / side	Directly trains the lateral trunk against cornering forces
Towel wring / thick-grip dumbbell hold	30–40 s	Forearm pump resistance — grip the wheel, not strangle it
Wrist roller (or band wrist flexion/extension)	1 slow up-down (15/15 reps)	Both directions: flexors for grip, extensors for vibration damping
Steering-wheel hold (plate held at 9-and-3, arms extended)	20–30 s	Use a 2.5–5 kg plate; add small left-right rotations in weeks 6–7

Session C — Conditioning & mobility

A typical kart stint keeps your heart rate at 85–95% of maximum for 10–20 minutes. Intervals at stint-like intensity teach your body to stay sharp under that load — most amateurs lose lap time to fatigue-driven concentration drops, not to lack of pace.

Week	Intervals (bike / row / run)	Then finish with
Week 1	4 × 3 min hard (RPE 6–7) / 2 min easy	10 min mobility: neck, hips, thoracic spine
Week 2	4 × 3 min hard (RPE 7) / 2 min easy	10 min mobility
Week 3	5 × 3 min hard (RPE 7–8) / 2 min easy	10 min mobility + 5 min breathing (slow nasal exhale)
Week 4 (deload)	20 min continuous easy (RPE 5)	15 min full mobility routine
Week 5	5 × 3 min hard (RPE 7–8) / 90 s easy	10 min mobility
Week 6	6 × 3 min hard (RPE 8) / 2 min easy	10 min mobility + 5 min breathing
Week 7	6 × 3 min hard (RPE 8) / 90 s easy	10 min mobility
Week 8 (taper)	20 min continuous easy (RPE 5)	15 min full mobility routine, early night

Race / track-day weekend routine

When	What to do
Two days before	Last hard session (Session B, reduced to 2 rounds). Hydrate deliberately from here on.
Day before	Rest or 20 min easy movement + mobility. Prepare kit; sleep is a performance tool.
Morning of	10 min activation: neck isometrics (1 round, easy), band pull-aparts, bodyweight squats, wrist circles.
Between stints	Walk, sip water (add electrolytes in heat), gentle neck and forearm stretches. Avoid sitting slumped.
Evening after	10 min easy spin or walk + light stretching; protein-rich meal within 2 hours.

Recovery rules

- **Sleep beats supplements.** Aim for 7.5–9 h, especially the two nights before an event.
- **Track your neck.** If neck soreness from a previous session hasn't cleared, cut Session B neck volume in half rather than skipping it.
- **Hydration:** karting in a suit and helmet can cost 1–2 L of sweat per hour in summer. Weigh yourself before/after a practice day once to learn your rate.
- **Do not train to failure** in deload/taper weeks (4 and 8) or within 48 h of an event.

Progress tracking

Log these once per week and compare across the eight weeks: side-plank hold time per side, steering-wheel plate hold time, longest interval at RPE 8, and — most importantly — **at which lap of a stint you first notice neck or forearm fatigue**. That last number is the one this plan exists to move.

Disclaimer: This is a sample TrackReady programme for informational purposes and is not medical advice. Consult a physician before starting a new training programme, and stop any exercise that causes pain. The full TrackReady service starts with a digital assessment so your plan matches your history, schedule and events.